

Center for Career Design: Student Perceptions and Internship Engagement

Coyote Business Consulting – Fall 2025

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Executive Summary

The University of South Dakota's Center for Career Design (a new office on campus) has partnered with Coyote Business Consulting (CBC) to understand how students (except for departments on campus with dedicated career placement offices, e.g., the Knudson School of Law), perceive the internship search process, identify common challenges, and evaluate the awareness of existing career resources on campus.

The two student consultants who worked on this project are Grace Rooney, an MBA student with an undergraduate USD business degree in healthcare administration, and Tyson Test, a senior undergraduate business honors student with an Economics and Business Analytics dual-major degree.

This project combined a literature review surveying research done on this topic throughout the country with a student survey of 436 respondents representing the diverse array of academic programs on campus. Our survey clearly shows strong interest in internships among students, but low engagement with institutional support services. 62% of respondents expressed high interest in completing an internship prior to graduation, yet 80% of respondents have never utilized the Center for Career Design. Underutilization of campus career services is mainly driven by a lack of awareness among the general student population about the Center's existence and services offered.

Our research shows that students value paid, skill-building internships with opportunities to benefit from mentors in the organization. Students at USD (as is common among the Gen-Z cohort) value clear communication about expectations and outcomes from an internship provider. This report concludes with actionable recommendations to improve communication, accessibility, and student engagement with the Center's programs and services.

Introduction

Coyote Business Consulting (CBC) serves as a bridge between the Beacom School of Business and the broader community, connecting business students with organizations seeking strategic insights. For Fall 2025, a CBC consultant team partnered with USD's new Center for Career Design to evaluate how effectively USD's career and internship support resources meet the needs of students, particularly regarding awareness and accessibility.

Nationally, institutions are rethinking career readiness models to reflect changing student and job market needs. The "placement" model, where colleges play the role of matchmaker between employer and student, has begun to evolve into a more holistic "career design model" which emphasizes skill development, exploration, and self-efficacy among students. This evolution in approach is motivated by the changing nature of work. The old model of work, which prevailed in the 20th century, consisted of long-term stays at larger companies, with internal promotions to advance and a defined-benefit retirement plan to motivate loyalty, has gone by the wayside.

This model has been replaced in the modern job market — one that features shorter stints of employment at companies (with small businesses driving more of the employment gains); more frequent turnover; and increased switching of employers for career advancement — a shift largely motivated by employers, many of whom now place less emphasis on employee loyalty, as demonstrated by the demise of defined-benefit retirement plans, which have been replaced by the now nearly ubiquitous defined-contribution plan that shifts risk to employees and enhances portability across employers. In recognition of these changes, colleges seek to inculcate the skills needed to navigate this "new normal," such as resume writing and customization to the job description, job search strategies, and networking, which are more important now than in the past.

USD's Center for Career Design aims to adopt this modern approach. By understanding how students currently perceive internships and campus resources, the Center can design more

inclusive, high-impact programs tailored to the needs of Gen Z and the unique context of a rural-serving university.

Methodology

Literature Review

Our team reviewed findings from major sources in this field of study, including:

- NACE (National Association of Colleges and Employers) 2024 Student Survey Executive Summary
- Scholarly research on rural career development (Reardon et al, 2019; Byun et al, 2017; Hora, 2021)

Key themes emerged from our review of existing literature:

- Students want paid, meaningful work with opportunities for mentorship and clear learning outcomes
- Engagement with career offices depends on awareness, accessibility, and perceived relevance
- Rural students face unique challenges, including limited local opportunities, transportation barriers, and a preference for relationship-based support models

Survey Design

The CBC team wrote and distributed a 30-question online survey developed using Qualtrics.

Special thanks go to USD Girls' Swap, Delta Sigma Pi Alpha Eta chapter, and the *Honors Weekly* e-mail newsletter for helping us distribute the survey.

- Demographics: 83% traditional students, 41% first generation, 32% freshman, 24% sophomore, 18% junior, 12% seniors, and 15% grad students
- By department/program on campus: 34% Beacom, 27% Arts & Sciences, 26% Health Sciences, 9% Education, and 3% Fine Arts

- Topics Covered: Awareness, usage, barriers, preferences, and perceptions of career readiness. Both quantitative (multiple-choice and Likert) and qualitative (open-ended) questions were asked.

Key Findings

Awareness and Engagement

- 63% of students are aware of the Center's existence, yet only 20% have ever utilized its services
- Only 28% of students say that they are "extremely familiar" or "somewhat familiar" with the Center's services
- Common introduction channels include faculty, academic advisors, and university emails
- Students commonly cite a communication gap in qualitative feedback, with this response being representative: "I think the resources are there, but I don't think a lot of people are aware of what all is available to them and how to get in touch with someone."

Student Values and Preferences

- Paid internships are preferred by 95% of students
- Students desire real work experience, mentorship, and career relevance over general exposure
- Hybrid formats are popular, students value flexibility but still want in-person mentorship
- Cultural and mission alignment matter: Gen Z students cite purpose, inclusivity, and authenticity as important in organizations when seeking internships

Barriers to Participation

Students (who could select more than one option, which is why the percentages add up to more than 100%) tend to cite the following three concerns as keeping them from getting internships:

- Uncertainty about how to find or apply: 56%
- Finances (need to do paid work): 48%

- Lack of time to search for an internship (course load, activities, etc): 43%

Those from smaller hometowns frequently mentioned limited access to local opportunities and reliable transportation. These findings align with literature describing “place-bound” rural students who prefer nearby roles.

Resource Use and Effectiveness

Among students who have used the Center’s services:

- Resume reviews and job search were the most accessed
- Among students who have used the center: 49% said it was “somewhat helpful” and 30% said it was “very helpful.”
- Few respondents have participated in workshops or mock interviews, suggesting underutilization of some services. The center may want to offer these services to those who initially ask for resume reviews (one might call it a form of “cross-selling”).

Internship Interest and Confidence

- 62% of students reported being “very interested” in completing an internship before graduating
- Only 7% said they have “low confidence” in finding an internship
- The strongest predictors of confidence were familiarity with Center services and having previous work experience

Assistance Needed

When asked what would be most helpful to them, students said:

- Financial support/stipends/scholarships: 60%
- More employer connections in my field: 56%
- Step-by-step application guidance: 55%

Synthesis of Literature and USD Data

Our survey results reinforce national findings: awareness, affordability, and alignment are the pillars of internship engagement. The literature and USD results point to:

- Paid opportunities are a key equity issue
- Trust and relationship-based advising is especially important for first-generation and rural students
- Faculty integration is critical for reaching disengaged students

Recommendations

The Center may consider an embedded career development approach, connecting classroom learning, campus services, and student life design rather than passively assuming students will show up asking for help.

- Visibility and awareness: enhance existing partnerships with faculty to give freshman students 5-minute presentations about the Center and the services it offers (the same can be done for senior-level students about grad school workshops), using the provided PowerPoint.
 - Purpose: immediate low-cost outreach and relationship building
- Financial concerns: establish small internship stipends, possibly in collaboration with local employers/communities (if possible, and/or USD has matching funds).
- Curricular integration: continue embedding career readiness modules into freshman first-year experience classes.
 - Purpose: institutionalize career development as part of the learning process (does not make classroom talks redundant).
- Digital outreach: establish a presence on LinkedIn, consider posting “student success” testimonials on Instagram

- Continuous feedback loop: implement annual satisfaction surveys for all students who use Center services, track internship-to-job conversion rates, and develop a culture in the Center of continuous improvement.

Conclusion

The Center for Career Design plays an important role in helping USD students translate classroom learning into meaningful professional experiences. This project revealed that while students overwhelmingly value internships and career preparation, many lack knowledge about the Center and what it can do for them.

These findings underscore the need for enhanced visibility, clarity, and connection to the student body. Strengthening communication through classroom engagement, digital outreach, and improved presence for freshman students will ensure the Center is recognized and trusted by the student body as a key resource for career and life design.

By prioritizing these recommendations, the Center can foster a more informed, confident, and career-ready student population. The improvements will also complement the efforts of the CBC employer outreach team, ensuring that once the results of their efforts bear fruit, students will be well-prepared and motivated to take advantage of these opportunities.